WoW: Forever Wraps the Biggest Beta in Franchise History

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World of Warcraft: Forever has just finished the largest **beta** test in the history of the game, according to Microsoft CEO Satya Nadella. A **beta** test lets players try a game before it is fully ready. Before, players had to sign up and hope Blizzard picked them. This time, Blizzard also gave **beta** access to players who bought the War Within and Midnight **expansions**. An unofficial tool, ClassicPlus.io, suggests over one million **characters** were created during the **beta**. Developer Josh Greenfield called the turnout the craziest numbers he had seen in 17 years at Blizzard and almost 8 years working on classic games. In a post on September 18, 2026, he said he was so excited he could hardly sleep. The game is a sort of **alternate universe** version of World of Warcraft, set in the world of the original game but with different twists in its story and content. The **beta** ran from September 17 through October 23. The full game launches on November 4 for anyone with an existing World of Warcraft **subscription**.

Word Treasure

beta -- A test version of a game that players try before it is fully ready.
expansions -- Extra parts added to a game with new stories and content to explore.
characters -- The pretend people that players create and control in a game.
alternate universe -- A version of a story world that is familiar but has different twists.
subscription -- A payment plan that lets someone keep using a game or service.

Background you need

World of Warcraft is a popular online game where players create characters and explore a shared fantasy world together.

A beta test lets players try a game before it is fully ready so the makers can find problems and improve it.

An alternate universe version keeps the same world but changes parts of the story and content.

Break it down

WHO: Blizzard, World of Warcraft players, and developer Josh Greenfield
WHAT: World of Warcraft: Forever finished the largest beta test in the history of the game
WHERE: In World of Warcraft: Forever, set in the world of the original game
WHY: So players could try the game before it was fully ready, ahead of its full launch

Why it matters

If you play games, it shows why test versions exist: players get to try new worlds early and help find problems before everyone plays.

Test what you remember

1. What does a beta test let players do?

- (A) Watch other people play
- (B) Try a game before it is fully ready
- (C) Buy the full game early
- (D) Create a new game

2. Besides signing up and hoping to be picked, how did some players get beta access this time?

- (A) By winning a contest
- (B) By playing the original game for a long time
- (C) By asking a friend
- (D) By buying the War Within and Midnight expansions

3. What did the unofficial tool ClassicPlus.io suggest about the beta?

- (A) One million players finished the game
- (B) Over one million copies were sold
- (C) Over one million characters were created during the beta
- (D) The beta lasted one million hours

4. When does the full game launch?

- (A) December 4
- (B) November 4
- (C) September 17
- (D) October 23

5. Who can play the full game when it launches?

- (A) Anyone with an existing World of Warcraft subscription
- (B) Anyone with a phone
- (C) Only players who bought the expansions
- (D) Only players picked for the beta

6. What kind of version of World of Warcraft is Forever?

- (A) A copy of the original game
- (B) A short phone game
- (C) A sort of alternate universe version set in the world of the original game but with different twists
- (D) A movie about the game

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: D 3: C 4: B 5: A 6: C

Questions to think about

1. Developer Josh Greenfield: He was very excited by the turnout and called it the craziest numbers he had seen.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):